

Readings

from **White Shell Woman** – by James Doss - adapted

There are more puzzles yet unsolved. And this is good. It would be a far poorer world if there were no riddles left to ponder. Like what makes gravity work. And why the world is filled with so-called ordinary people who never give up – no matter how tough life gets. These are very deep mysteries indeed.

1 Kings 19:4-8

But he himself went a day's journey into the wilderness, and came and sat down under a solitary broom tree. He asked that he might die: "It is enough; now, O LORD, take away my life, for I am no better than my ancestors." Then he lay down under the broom tree and fell asleep. Suddenly an angel touched him and said to him, "Get up and eat." He looked, and there at his head was a cake baked on hot stones, and a jar of water. He ate and drank, and lay down again. The angel of the LORD came a second time, touched him, and said, "Get up and eat, otherwise the journey will be too much for you." He got up, and ate and drank; then he went in the strength of that food forty days and forty nights to Horeb the mount of God.

Going On

I love this story about the prophet Elijah. There is so much that is familiar to us in terms of our own experiences. Parallels that most of us can relate to. I think this is one of the reasons that the Bible has lasted so long. The stories are timeless. Let me set the stage.

The prophet Elijah has just had a marvelous victory. It was around 860 B.C.E. and many people had turned from worshiping God to following the false god Baal. Elijah had been on a crusade, prophesying and calling people back to the old religion. But the people were stubborn and continued in their idolatry. Worst of all was the then King of Israel, Ahab and his wife Jezebel.

Elijah had been hounded and hunted by the king because he kept preaching a truth the king didn't want to hear. He finally decided to issue a challenge to the wayward king and all the followers of the false god Baal. There would be a test. The priests of Baal and the prophet of God would meet on Mount Carmel and each would prepare a sacrifice to their god. Each group would take one bull, cut it into pieces and put it on wood piled on an altar, but not set it on fire. Then each would call upon the name of their god, and the god that answered by fire and burned up the sacrifice would be acknowledged as the true God.

So the challenge is met. Four hundred fifty priests of Baal come to this test. They put their bull on their altar and pray to their god from morning till noon, and nothing happens. They shout louder. No response. They shout even louder, they dance around the altar. They do all they can to get their god's attention. Still nothing. Finally in desperation they start to cut and slash themselves in the hopes that their own blood flowing will cause Baal to take their sacrifice. Nothing happens.

Now it is Elijah's turn. He rebuilds an old broken down altar from the Israelites and digs a trench around it. He puts the bull on the wood. And then he does something odd. He has the people pour 4 large jars of water on top of the sacrifice so it was soaking wet. Then he had them pour water on the sacrifice two more times. There was so much water that it filled the trench he had dug around the altar.

Then Elijah prayed. He said one simple prayer asking God to take the sacrifice so that everyone would know that the Lord is God. And wooosh! Fire comes down from heaven. The sacrifice is burned up, the wood is

burned up, and even the stone altar and all the water is burned up. Nothing is left.

When the people saw this, they fell to their knees and cried out "The Lord is God! The Lord is God." Elijah had won a great victory. Things were looking very good.

But as so often happens after a victory, there is a crash. Queen Jezebel is furious that her priests of Baal were defeated and she vows that she will have Elijah killed within twenty four hours. And so Elijah runs for his life and we find him exhausted and discouraged and sitting under a broom tree.

I'm fascinated with these slumps that follow success. Most of us know about them. They are so common that both religion and psychology have come up with theories about why they happen. When I was young, I remember going to religious camp and it was a powerful, exciting, holy, and wonderful experience. All us kids would come back excited about our faith and our church. We had a taste of what spirituality could be about. And the elders of the church would warn us. They would say "Be careful. After the mountain top experience, there will be a valley. In a little while something will happen that will make you feel like you are crashing and burning. It's the devil, trying to take away your victory." And often what they said came true. Something would happen in our lives after a great experience and we'd end up feeling defeated and down.

In some psychological circles they use the term "Upleveling." It carries the same idea, but has a different explanation. After a wonderful, positive event, people often end up having negative feelings. We are so uncomfortable with really feeling good and victorious and happy and positive that on an unconscious level we reach our limit of good feelings, and so find something to bring us down. We are uncomfortable going to a new level, hence the term – "Upleveling."

I've come to expect this phenomena in my own life and in that of others. When there is a big victory, it is often followed by a let down. And the thing to remember is that the let down does not cancel out the success. It just seems to be a regular part of the process. It doesn't really mean anything. Just that we crash for a while afterward.

And here is where we find Elijah. He feels like everything that he has done is for nothing. He has done all this work for his beliefs and what he knows is right, but it seems like nothing has really changed. Jezebel is still

queen and still a worshiper of Baal, so how can Israel ever really get back to their old faith. Elijah tells God that he just wants to die. He says, "I've had enough. I'm tired and frustrated and what I do doesn't matter anyway. Just let me die."

Have you ever felt that way? So discouraged that life does not seem worth living. So tired and beat up that you don't even want to go on. Let's just quit. It doesn't matter anymore. Sometimes we feel this way because of our health. We do what the doctors and therapists tell us and even if there is some improvement, it doesn't seem like enough. Nothing seems to have really changed. Why bother trying.

Or it could be about money – never feeling like we will get ahead no matter how hard we work.. Or perhaps the focus is a relationship that in our minds just never seems to move forward or get better.

Maybe it's work. You do your best, day in, day out. Determined not to fall into mediocre or a dull rut. You try to take your work seriously and see it as a service and as adding value to the world. But then there are times when it seems that it is a joke. Why put up with the bozos you have to deal with? Why care about the stupid rules? It is just too much.

There are many areas where we can feel like Elijah did. We too want to just sit down under a broom tree and give up. We're done. We're tired and mad and sick at heart and oh God, why can't this just be over? Why can't we just die? We know that feeling.

Then the miracle happens. Now a miracle can be a supernatural event. Or, another definition for miracle is a change of perspective. Our passage tells us:

Then Elijah lay down under the broom tree and fell asleep. Suddenly an angel touched him and said to him, "Get up and eat." He looked, and there at his head was a cake baked on hot stones, and a jar of water. He ate and drank, and lay down again. The angel of the LORD came a second time, touched him, and said, "Get up and eat, otherwise the journey will be too much for you." He got up, and ate and drank; then he went in the strength of that food forty days and forty nights to Horeb the mount of God.

An angel came and touched Elijah. The angel fed him and made sure he had enough strength for the journey ahead.

There are, for many of us, times when we are touched by an angel. Do you know what the word angel means? It means "messenger of God" or if you prefer, "a messenger of good." Often, when we say the word angel, what pops into our minds is a celestial creature, white with wings and a halo. A beautiful, other worldly being. It smacks of syrupy images and sometimes a fanciful theology. There are many people who will tell you that this kind of angel has touched their lives and brought them sustenance when they most needed it.

Yet this understanding of angels as just celestial beings with wings is too narrow. Any person and anything that brings a message from on high is an angel. Whenever we have been touched, given the strength and encouragement we needed to go on, we have encountered such a message.

I want to share several stories with you of people who, like Elijah, were ready to give up. They were worn out and discouraged and frightened. They did not want to go on any more. And then, something happened. In some of the strangest ways, they were given a message, that just like Elijah, was food for their soul. They were able to go on.

One man, Frederick Buechner, tells about his daughter's illness. She was sick and things were not looking good. He was worried and sick of heart. There wasn't anything he could do and he felt powerless and afraid. The road ahead seemed too tough. He wanted to just quit. Fred says: "I remember sitting parked by the roadside once, terribly depressed and afraid about my daughter's illness and what was going on in our family, when out of nowhere a car came along down the highway with a license plate that bore on it the one word out of all the words in the dictionary that I needed most to see exactly then. The word was TRUST. What do you call a moment like that? Something to laugh off as the kind of joke life plays on us every once in a while? The word of God? I am willing to believe that maybe it was something of both, but for me it was an epiphany. The owner of the car turned out to be, as I'd suspected, a trust officer in a bank, and not long ago, having read an account I wrote of the incident somewhere, he found out where I lived and one afternoon brought me the license plate itself, which sits propped up on a bookshelf in my house to this day. It is rusty around the edges and a little battered, and it is also as holy a relic as I have ever seen."

There, when he needed it most, the word from the universe, a message from on high, comes on the license plate of a passing car. Like Elijah, Fred was given hope to go on.

Nancy is another woman who found herself blessed by an unexpected angel. She says: "When I was very ill, I had to receive weekly intravenous treatments. This went on for almost two years. Somewhere in the middle I lost my courage. It is hard to say which collapsed first, my soul or my veins, but collapse they both did. One day the search for a healthy vein became too painful. I pushed the needle away and cried. The nurse brought to my side a young girl, of about ten, who had battled cancer all her life. This child smiled at me and said, "You should have got one of these." Lifting her T-shirt, she showed me the hole that had been cut into her abdomen so that she could receive her treatments through a permanent plastic port. Then she put her hand, so small and soft, on mine and said, "You can take it." And I did."

A small child, with cancer and a port, in that moment was Nancy's angel. She was given what she needed to go on.

There were times that for Nancy, music was her angel. She writes: "Someday I may get to personally thank Patti La Belle for sharing her magnificent voice and extraordinary heart in song. Every week, for two winters and two summers, as I drove to and from the cancer clinic for treatments, I played her renditions of "Somewhere Over The Rainbow" and "There's A Winner In You" over and over. When I was frightened and thought I couldn't make one more trip, I played those songs to get me there. Afterward, when I was tired and afraid I couldn't make the drive home, I played them again. My spirits never failed to recover, and the miles just flew by. I found such courage and hope in her passionate music. In the midst of the darkest time of my life, that voice made me feel grateful to be alive..."

Remember, an angel is a messenger of Goodness. We are reminded that on some level we are not alone. The universe is not against us. There is an intelligence behind it all. We can find our way through. We have more resilience than we imagined. We have hope.

Here is another story. (From Joyce Rupp) "A woman told me she had taken home a church bulletin. In it was the quote: "The light shall never be overcome by the darkness." She felt drawn to that quote and placed it on her refrigerator door. The next day she went to the doctor for a physical

and discovered that she had a tumor in her breast....The quote she had saved was her greatest strength in the days to come. Even as she went for surgery she felt the light within her overcoming the darkness... When she learned the wonderful news that her tumor was benign she felt deep gratitude for the inner strength she had received from finding that simple quote."

A simple thing – a quote from a church bulletin. Yet it provided the message that woman needed to carry her through the long journey of her health concerns. It gave her strength.

One last story now. It is one of my favorites.

I believe in new beginnings, at new year's or anytime. I believe in them because I've had them. During my first year in theological school I was in despair about life, my own included.

One cold, dreary Chicago day during the worst of it, wandering aimlessly along 63rd Street, going silently crazy, I suddenly, without intending or willing it, turned and stepped into a fresh fruit bar and ordered a glass of orange juice.

I drank it unthinkingly, then tasted the juice, the pulp. And slowly something happened. The orangeness of that orange juice, its sweetness and sunfilled-ness, the feel of it going into my throat and into my body, awakened me. I remember mumbling to myself how those oranges were doing good by me, actually caring for me without my asking, and the least I could do was say – if not "thank you," - at least "okay."

Maybe if oranges could be such a pal - zinging good things through me - why not other things: the sun, the air, the sidewalk, the music pouring from the carillon bells of Rockefeller Chapel across the Midway. I finished my orange juice, walked back to the Meadville Library, wrote an A paper on Luther and the Anabaptists and went on into this ministry.

So I believe in turn-arounds, the chances we get to begin ourselves anew. Of course, I believe in effort, doing all I can to provide the conditions to make positive things happen. But I also have faith that when positive things don't happen when my best efforts seem useless, that down the street somewhere, around a corner, the gift awaits, like the grace of God in the peeling of a fruit, when I listened to the orange.

From Clarke Dewey Wells' book Ouch and Alleluia

Grace, a bit of encouragement and hope, brought about by a glass of orange juice.

Just like Elijah, the people in these stories were touched by an angel, a messenger of Good. And often life does this for us. Just when we are at the end of our rope, when we don't think we can go on any further, when we have crashed and burned and we're all done in, life speaks. Sometimes it is through something as simple as a church bulletin, reading exactly what we need to see. Sometimes it is through the words and music of a song, giving us courage and hope. Maybe it is through the touch of a child, or even the license plate of a passing car. It could even come through something as basic as a drink of orange juice.

Think about your life. Can you remember times that you have been encouraged, given what you need for the journey ahead? The times that we have been given messages are often hard to describe to others. How can some of it make sense? But it happens.

Next time you find yourself feeling like Elijah, remember what you have heard here today. If you find yourself in a big slump after something very positive, just remember, "Oh yeah, this is often part of the process. It doesn't mean that I've lost what I've gained." And the next time you feel like giving up, throwing in the towel, and calling it quits, remember Elijah and look for an angel. The messengers of God come in all manner of disguises. But there will be words to strengthen you and help you.

And finally, let me tell you the rest of the story. Elijah did get what he needed from the angel. He got food and rest and encouragement. He got up, traveled into the desert for 40 days, and then anointed both a new political ruler and a new religious ruler for the Israelites. Change had begun. The victory he had won back on Mount Carmel was not in vain and all that he had been working for did come to pass.

Take heart. Remember Elijah. And when you feel you can't go on, trust that there is more beyond yourself to help you and that there will be a message of encouragement and hope for you.

I close with one of my favorite benedictions:

Take courage friends.
The way is often hard,
The path is never clear,
And the stakes are very high.
Take courage.
For deep down, there is another truth:

You are not alone.

Amen and Amen.

